SYSDESIGN REFERENCE

Payment System Follow-Up Bank

Common interviewer pivots with tradeoff-oriented guidance.

Move money through an auditable state machine where retries never duplicate financial effects.

VERSION 1.0 REVIEW

REVIEWED THROUGH 2026-07-18

STATUS HUMAN REVIEW REQUIRED

SYSDESIGN / PAYMENT-SYSTEM

SYSDESIGN

Payment System Follow-Up Bank

CORE IDEA

Move money through an auditable state machine where retries never duplicate financial effects.

Reference architecture decision chain

01 Ledger	02 Authorization/Capture	03 Idempotency	04 Reconciliation

Decisions to defend

+ Ledger
+ authorization/capture
+ idempotency
+ reconciliation
+ webhooks
+ and compliance boundaries.

Failure modes to test

+ Double charge
+ lost webhook
+ ledger mismatch
+ partial refund
+ and provider outage.

Interview flow

- [ ] Clarify users, critical paths, and non-goals
- [ ] Estimate only scale that changes a decision
- [ ] Define API, data model, and source of truth
- [ ] Draw synchronous and asynchronous paths
- [ ] Pressure-test timeout, retry, overload, and recovery
- [ ] Close with tradeoffs and one alternative

Deep-dive drill

Payment System Follow-Up Bank

Probe	What a strong answer makes explicit
How does the design behave during a regional dependency failure?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
Which metric reveals the first bottleneck?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
What consistency does the user actually observe?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
How would the design change at ten times the traffic?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.

Data questions

+ Partition key
+ Versioning
+ Uniqueness
+ Retention
+ Reconciliation

Operations questions

+ SLO
+ Backlog
+ Capacity
+ Alert
+ Failover test

DESIGN DISCIPLINE

For every box: which requirement justifies it, what cost does it introduce, and what happens when it fails?

PUBLISHING STATUS
REVIEW GATE: TECHNICAL REVIEW. AI-produced draft. A named human must verify technical accuracy, sourcing, freshness, and editorial quality before publication. Reviewed-through date: 2026-07-18.